

BIRMINGHAM CLAUDE IMPACT LAB

CHALLENGE 4 • HOMELESSNESS HANDOFF

What happens now?

Birmingham publishes eleven real cooling stations. Finding out whether any of them is open today turns out to be the hard part.

— A worked example, not a model answer



Marcus

Mid-fifties. Sleeping behind a shuttered storefront off 2nd Avenue North.

He is not in anyone's system. Nobody is looking for him. He needs somewhere cool for a few hours.

Drawn from SCEN-01 in the event's synthetic dataset. The person is invented. Every address in this deck is real.

TIME

11:14 AM

HEAT INDEX

99°F

STANDING NEXT TO HIM

An outreach volunteer with a phone, a pen, and about ten minutes before she has to move on.

She does not need a database. She needs to know one thing: **where can he go, right now, that is actually open.**

THE GOOD NEWS

Birmingham already runs a cooling-station program

01 **Birmingham Public Library**
2100 Park Place

02 **Faith Chapel Care Center**
921 2nd Ave. North

03 **Pathways**
409 Richard Arrington Jr. Blvd. North
women and children only

04 **Firehouse Ministries**
626 2nd Ave. North

05 **North Birmingham Library**
2501 31st Ave. N

06 **Fitness Center**
421 Rev. Abraham Woods Jr Blvd

07 **Five Points West Library**
4812 Ave. W

08 **One Roof**
730 8th Ave. West

09 **Harrison Recreation Center**
901 17th St SW

10 **Southside Library**
1814 11th Ave. South

11 **Woodlawn Library**
5709 1st Ave. N

Five quadrants, real addresses, published hours for each. So the volunteer has a list. Only one of the eleven says who it serves, and the city's list is not where that came from.

birminghamal.gov/homelessness
retrieved 28 Aug 2026

FINDING ONE

The list is not a schedule

Those eleven stations are **activated**, not standing. They open only when the temperature or heat index reaches 95°F.

Being on the list and being open today are two different facts. A page that just showed the list would be promising eleven open doors.



99°F does not mean they are open. Crossing 95° is what makes activation possible, not what confirms it – and an activation can begin later in the day. Somebody still has to check.

So call ahead. Call who?

THE CITY'S LIST

Publishes no phone number. For any station.

Names, addresses, hours. Nothing to dial. A workflow built on “call before anyone travels” gets nothing from the source that matters.

SO WE FOLLOWED THE REFERRALS

The trail loops, then goes cold.

United Way 211 → points to county EMA and Health

County EMA → lists nothing, says ask Health

County Health → the words “heat” and “cooling” do not appear on the site

211

is the one number that reaches a human, so everything routes there. But 211 is a referral line, not the city's activation system, and the card says so rather than pretending otherwise.

A card that refuses to help too early

No handoff is produced until a person has called and written down what they were told. Everything after that point is only the confirmed facts.

The output stays visible but locked, and names exactly what is still missing. Hiding it would just look broken.

LOCKED UNTIL THE CALL IS CONFIRMED

Still needed:

- which station 211 named
- whether anyone confirmed it is open today
- what time it is open until
- the time you called 211
- your initials, so the follow-up has an owner

The phone call is the part that cannot be automated, so the card is built around protecting it.

Sometimes the right output is no output

Stations are not activated today. Do not send anyone.

No card is produced. Instead: try 211 again, check the city's activation page, and stay with shade and water in the meantime. Shelter goes through One Roof.

A tool that always produces an answer will eventually produce a wrong one.

Sending Marcus walking to a locked door in 99°F heat is the specific harm this whole thing exists to prevent.

“They couldn't say” is treated as its own answer too, not as a yes.

Station 03 would not have taken him

STATION 03 ON THAT LIST

Pathways

409 Richard Arrington Jr. Blvd. North

City-published hours: Mon–Fri 9 a.m.–3 p.m.

Serves women and children only

The city's list says nothing about eligibility for any of the eleven. We only found this on the organization's own site.

On the list it looks like the other ten: a name, an address, opening hours. Nothing on it tells a volunteer that this one cannot take a man in his fifties — and he is the one who would have made the walk in the heat.

So eligibility rides with the address: in the dropdown, on the responder's log, and as the **first line** of the card handed over, ahead of anything about hours.

THE PART WE GOT WRONG FIRST

There is no printer on a sidewalk

We built a screen. But the call happens at a desk and the handoff happens on the street, and we had quietly assumed those were the same place.

So the page also prints a blank. You run a stack before your shift and fill one in with a pen while standing with someone. Stations get circled, not copied out, so an address cannot be written down wrong.

Because the addresses and the numbers are already printed on it, the paper works with **no signal and a dead battery.**

The two conditions the digital version cannot survive.



WHAT THIS DOES NOT DO

The honest list

IT GOES STALE

The station list is a snapshot from one day. Nothing in the page can tell you when that stopped being true.

ENTRY RULES ARE UNKNOWN

No source states an ID or residency rule, and none rules one out. The card never claims “no ID needed” on its own authority.

NIGHTS ARE UNCOVERED

The latest any station closes is 8 p.m., and that is two libraries on Tuesdays. Ten of the eleven shut by 6, one at 12:30. On Sundays only two publish hours at all.

IT IS HEAT RELIEF, NOTHING MORE

Shelter and housing run through One Roof Coordinated Entry. This does not replace it, and never decides a placement.

Marcus is invented, and so is everything around him — the hour, the temperature, the street, the volunteer. The eleven stations, their addresses and their hours are real, and cited on slide 3.



NEXT STEP TOWARD A PILOT

Give it to one outreach team for a week of heat advisories

THEN ASK THEM ONE QUESTION

Did the person arrive, and was the building open when they got there?

Nothing else tells you whether the confirmation gate does any good. Until someone runs that week, the rest of this is a guess.

TWO CHEAPER ASKS

Ask the city to publish a phone number for each station. Their absence is the only reason this detours through 211.

Ask 211 whether it receives the city's activation notices. We could not establish that it does — and if it does not, the referral its own heat page recommends cannot be answered on the days it counts.